

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN DJIBOUTI

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the water, salt flats, coasts, and pastoral lands of Djibouti. Community action genuinely shapes what happens to the water, the salt flats, the coasts, and the pastoral lands of Djibouti — but here the setting is distinctive, because Djibouti is a tiny, strategically pivotal, desperately water-scarce nation whose development is dominated by ports, foreign bases, and debt, and whose gravest environmental question is simply whether its people, above all its rural herders, will have water to live. Djibouti has no rivers that run year-round and almost no rain; it has among the least fresh water per person of any nation on earth, far below the threshold of absolute scarcity; Djibouti has no rivers at all that run year-round and receives almost no rain; it has among the very least fresh water per person of any nation anywhere on earth, far below even the recognised threshold of absolute water scarcity; its groundwater is being drawn down faster than it can refill and is turning salty; and its droughts, worsening with the climate, fall hardest on the pastoralist communities of the interior, where fewer than half have safe water while the capital has far more. Its recurring droughts, worsening steadily with the changing climate, fall hardest on the pastoralist communities of the arid interior, where fewer than half the people have safe water to drink while the capital has far more. Into this scarcity the nation builds desalination plants, pipes water from a neighbour, and pursues ports, free zones, and industry along its coasts and salt flats. Into the teeth of this scarcity the nation builds desalination plants, pipes water in from a neighbour, and pursues ports, free zones, and heavy industry along its coasts and salt flats. This guide will be honest that Djibouti faces a genuine water and development crisis with few options, that it is poor and heavily indebted and its choices constrained, that its environment is shaped by a geopolitics of chokepoints and bases beyond its control, that political space is limited, and that no single victory is to be won; but it will show that the levers here — the sustainability of the water, the clean-energy path the nation itself aspires to, the rural people's fair claim, the unique natural heritage, and the leverage of the international funders — are real, and can be used, carefully.

The Djiboutian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Djiboutian, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because water is Djibouti's binding constraint, because the nation itself aspires to clean energy that could power a sustainable water future, because the rural herders have a fair claim to the water and investment they are denied, because the salt lakes and coasts are a unique heritage worth more whole, and because the international funders who finance Djibouti's development carry real leverage, the levers run through sustainability, equity, heritage, and finance: the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage.** That combination — the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state, the case for sustainable, equitable, clean development is one the nation's own aspirations and its funders' rules can be made to serve.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The crisis is real, the nation is poor and indebted, the space is constrained, and geopolitics shapes much.** Djibouti

genuinely lacks water and genuinely needs development, so it builds desalination and pursues the ports and industry that are its livelihood, and opposition must reckon with that necessity rather than merely refuse; the nation is poor, heavily indebted to foreign lenders, and dependent on the ports and bases for its revenue, so its autonomy is limited; the political space for open opposition is constrained in an authoritarian state; and much of Djibouti's fate is set by its strategic location and its powerful foreign partners, beyond ordinary reach. This guide does not pretend the water crisis is easily solved, or that the nation has good options it ignores, or that opposition is free. What it shows is how, through the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage, communities can press for water that lasts, development that is clean and fair, and a heritage kept whole — carefully, within the space that exists, and with honest regard for a genuine crisis.

Most people who care about Djibouti's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state offers. They see the groundwater drawn down and salting, the herders left dry while the capital drinks, the salt flats and coasts eyed for industry — and either accept it as the price of survival and strategy, or despair of a constrained space, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path the nation itself wants, the rural people's fair claim, the unique heritage, the funders' leverage. The gap between water that lasts and water that fails is here often a gap of method — the method of using the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Djiboutian reality as it is, which is a tiny, strategically pivotal, water-scarce, indebted, authoritarian state. It is written for the person — in a pastoralist community, in Djibouti's small technical and civic world, or among its international partners — who sees the water failing and the heritage threatened and wants to know what can be done in a nation whose crisis is real and whose space is narrow. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage — with the honest qualifiers that the crisis is genuine, the nation poor and indebted, the space constrained, and geopolitics dominant, so the work is careful, within-system advocacy for sustainable, equitable, clean development, not open confrontation. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Djiboutian case is particular. It is for the person — a member of a pastoralist or coastal community, a water or energy professional, someone in Djibouti's small civic world, or an international partner — willing to do the patient, careful, within-system work of pressing a poor, indebted, strategically-bound state toward the sustainable and fair development it says it wants, rather than either accepting the depletion of the nation's water as unavoidable or courting an open confrontation that an authoritarian state makes both ineffective and risky. That is not a lesser ambition but, in Djibouti's conditions, the effective and honest one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage, all of which are reached through the funders and the system rather than against the state. Anyone who approaches Djibouti demanding that a poor nation simply forgo development will achieve nothing; anyone who approaches it insisting that development be sustainable, clean, and fair, as the nation and its funders themselves profess, stands on ground both strong and defensible. This guide is an honest map of that path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the project, the harm, and the fair alternative)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- water, equity, heritage)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community and the technical coalition)

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & RESOURCE-GOVERNANCE (sustainability, clean energy, donors)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a sustainable-and-fair-development cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the water and the harm feeds the sustainability case, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage at once; the community and the technical experts organise within the constraints; a sustainability argument, an equity claim, or a donor's safeguard is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of securing water, fairness, and heritage.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Djibouti's — a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed, strategically vital state — give a distinctive set:

- **The water's sustainability.** In one of the world's most water-scarce nations, **a project that depletes or salts the water is self-defeating** — the distinctive lever.
- **The clean-energy path.** Djibouti's own **aspiration to clean, renewable energy** — geothermal and more — could power a sustainable water future.
- **The rural claim.** The **rural herders' fair claim** to the water and investment they are denied is a powerful equity argument.
- **The natural heritage.** The **salt lakes, forests, and coasts** are a unique heritage worth more whole than industrialised.
- **The donor leverage.** The **international funders** of Djibouti's development carry safeguards and leverage over an indebted state.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that Djibouti has good options it ignores. The crisis is **real**; the nation is **poor and indebted**; the space is **constrained**; and geopolitics is **dominant**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it seeks sustainable, fair development, not mere refusal — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage — to press for water that lasts and a heritage kept whole, honestly acknowledging the crisis, the poverty and debt, the constrained space, and the weight of geopolitics.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through a poor, indebted, water-scarce state's own aspirations and its funders' rules, because Djibouti will not simply forgo development, but it can be steered toward sustainability and held to its own goals. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage apply, because in Djibouti a destructive project is met not by open confrontation, which is constrained, nor by mere refusal, which ignores a real need, but by showing it undermines the water the nation cannot spare, and by pressing the clean, fair, funded alternative the nation itself aspires to.

The Levels of Decision

A Djiboutian project runs through a small, centralised, donor-financed system.

The state and its agencies. The **state, the water and energy authorities, and the development agencies** drive and decide the projects, and are the authority to be persuaded — with sustainability and the nation's own goals — rather than confronted.

The national plans and the law. The **national development vision, the water and energy strategies, and the environmental law** are the state's own standards, and a real channel, since holding the state to its own aspirations is a genuine path.

The international funders. The **international lenders and donors** — the development banks and partners financing the water, energy, and ports — carry safeguards and leverage over an indebted state.

The technical and civic bodies. The **water and energy experts, the technical institutions, and what civil society exists** can document and advocate within the constraints.

The rural and coastal communities. The **pastoralist and coastal communities** who bear the water scarcity and the coastal harm can act, within the constraints, on their fair claim.

The Journey of a Project

A Djiboutian project — a well field over-drawing an aquifer, a port or industry on the coast, salt works at the lake, a desalination plant — moves from a state plan driven by need and strategy, through the funding and the assessment, toward the built project or the protected resource, with the **water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage** able to intervene. **The water's sustainability and the donor leverage are where the project is best met, and the clean-energy path and the rural claim are the fair alternative** — and using them together is the distinctive Djiboutian approach. The distinctive levers are the **water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what water, heritage, or community it harms, how it threatens the water the nation cannot spare or the fairness it owes, and how the clean-energy path and the donor leverage can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Water, and the Funder

Behind a project stand the state, its need and strategy, and the water and heritage at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **how it threatens the water's sustainability, what clean, fair alternative the nation itself aspires to, what the rural people are owed, and which funders and safeguards apply**. Two questions unlock most Djiboutian efforts: **What is harmed, and how does it threaten the water and fairness the nation needs?** and **Which lever — the sustainability, the clean energy, the rural claim, the heritage, the donors — can meet it, while serving a real need?** The water's sustainability, the donor leverage, and the clean-energy path are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Djiboutian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the harm to the scarce water and the fairness owed; the community-and-funder coalition exists to press that case through the affected people, the experts, and the lenders; and the media, largely international, exists to raise the stakes for a state mindful of its aspirations and its standing. Keep the water's sustainability, the donor leverage, and the clean-energy path at the centre of every submission, claim, and appeal, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single drawn-down well or threatened coast to the survival of a water-scarce nation and the clean future it professes to want, grounding the whole effort in the sustainability, the equity, and the finance that a poor, indebted, water-scarce state cannot easily refuse.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers. The **state, the water and energy authorities, and the development agencies**; the **national plans and the law**; the **international funders and their safeguards**; the **technical and civic bodies**; and the **rural and coastal communities**. In Djibouti, the **water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to deplete the water the nation cannot spare, to deny the rural people their claim, or to threaten a unique heritage, when a clean and fair alternative exists and the funders can insist on it, can genuinely be pressed — through the sustainability case, the donor leverage, and the clean-energy path — though, honestly, the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, the space constrained, and geopolitics dominant, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep seeking a sustainable, fair path.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, and the space constrained, even as the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how water-and-development conflicts tend to go in Djibouti and comparable small, donor-financed states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **shown to threaten the water or the fairness the nation needs**, whether the **clean, fair alternative** can be offered, and whether the **donor leverage** can be brought to bear. Where the sustainability case is strong and the funders engage, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the crisis is genuine, the nation has real need, and the space is narrow.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Water-sustainability argument	40–60%	months–years	low	The self-defeating harm shown
Clean-energy / nexus alternative	35–55%	years	high	Sustainable water and power advanced
Rural-equity claim	35–55%	months–years	low	The rural people's fair claim pressed
Natural-heritage case	35–55%	months–years	low	The salt lakes, forests, coasts protected
Donor-leverage / safeguards	40–60%	months–years	low	The funders' protections enforced
Regional / international	35–55%	months–years	low	The shared waters and commitments engaged
All levers together	35–55%	months–years	moderate	Sustainable, fair development secured

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Djibouti's real strengths are the water constraint, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules: the **water's sustainability**, the **clean-energy path**, the **rural claim**, the **heritage**, and the **donor leverage**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the crisis is **real**, the nation **poor and indebted**, the space **constrained**, and geopolitics **dominant** — so progress comes

through sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage, not through mere refusal or open confrontation.

*A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a sustainability argument, an equity claim, a heritage case, an appeal to a funder's safeguards — cost mainly organisation and knowledge. The clean-energy and water infrastructure is the costly lever, but it is the funders' to supply, and Djibouti's own aspiration. The scarce resources are **the technical capacity, the connection to the international funders, and the careful navigation of a constrained state** — much of it reachable through the donors and the regional water bodies. This shapes where a Djiboutian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are technical and scientific credibility, connection to the international funders whose safeguards and finance shape the nation's development, and the judgement to navigate a constrained state safely — rather than the mass mobilisation that other struggles require and that here would be both constrained and risky — an effort's most valuable investments are in building technical credibility, cultivating the funder relationships, and documenting the water and the harm rigorously. A small, credible, well-connected effort that can marshal the state's and the funders' own water science, make the sustainability case, offer the clean alternative, and engage the lenders' safeguards can accomplish a great deal in a donor-financed state. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of credibility, funder connection, and careful judgement — much of it reachable through the donors, the regional water bodies, and the international environmental partners, and all within the grasp of a determined, careful coalition. And because the nation is poor and indebted, the arguments that serve sustainability and equity and engage the funders, rather than merely refuse, are the most persuasive.*

Effectiveness Visualization

SUSTAINABILITY + CLEAN ENERGY + RURAL CLAIM + HERITAGE + DONOR LEVERAGE:

Water-sustainability argument: ■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Donor-leverage / safeguards: ■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Clean-energy / nexus: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Rural-equity claim: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Natural-heritage case: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

REAL CRISIS / POOR & INDEBTED / GEOPOLITICS -- harder ground:

Mere refusal, no alternative: ■■ ignores real need

Sustainable & fair path: ■■■■■■■■■■ the real path

Water secured / heritage kept: ■■■■■■■■■■ achievable in part

The harm documented: ■■■■■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Djibouti are **the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage** — used together, and offering a fair, sustainable path. The sustainability and donor levers show the ceiling: a project shown to undermine scarce water, against a fair alternative the funders can insist on, can genuinely be curbed or improved. The real crisis and the poverty and debt show the honest floor: the nation needs water and development and has few options. Most Djiboutian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to make the sustainability case, offer the clean alternative, press the rural claim and the heritage, and invoke the donors — but that mere refusal ignores a real need, and the surest result is that the harm is documented and a sustainable, fair path advanced.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The water's sustainability and the donor leverage** — Djibouti's distinctive strengths; the binding constraint and the funders' hold.
2. **The clean-energy path** — the sustainable alternative the nation itself aspires to.
3. **The rural claim** — the herders' fair claim to water and investment.

4. **The natural heritage** — the salt lakes, forests, and coasts worth keeping whole.
5. **The documented harm** — the evidence of depletion, inequity, and loss that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Water is the binding constraint** — a project that depletes or salts it is self-defeating. **The nation aspires to clean energy** — its own renewable goal is a lever for a sustainable path. **The rural people bear the burden** — their fair claim is a powerful argument. **The heritage is unique** — the salt lakes and coasts are worth more whole. **The funders have leverage** — an indebted state's donors can insist on sustainability. **But the crisis is real and the space narrow** — so the path is a fair, funded one, carefully pressed. The through-line: **document the harm; show it threatens the water and fairness the nation needs; offer the clean-energy path the nation itself wants; press the rural claim and the heritage; invoke the donor leverage; and serve a real need** — because an effort that does can genuinely secure sustainable, fair development, while being honest that the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, and no victory final.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through sustainability, equity, and the funders. Vague concern goes nowhere, and mere refusal ignores a real need; an effort aimed at "this project depleting this water or harming this heritage or people, threatening the water the nation cannot spare or the fairness it owes, when this clean, fair alternative exists and these funders can insist on it" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What is harmed?** This is the first question here. What **water, heritage, or community** does the project threaten — the drawn-down aquifer, the salting water, the salt lake or coast, the rural herders.
2. **How does it threaten the water or the fairness the nation needs?** How the harm **depletes or salts the scarce water, or denies the rural people their fair claim** to water and investment.
3. **What clean, fair alternative exists?** What **clean-energy, sustainable-water, and equitable alternative** — the nation's own aspiration — could serve the need with less harm.
4. **What heritage is at stake?** What **unique natural heritage** — the salt lakes, the forest, the coast and its life — the project threatens, and its value kept whole.
5. **Which funders apply, and how to work safely?** Which **international funders and safeguards** can be brought to bear, and how the effort proceeds through international, technical, and within-system channels, carefully.

A Worked Example

Suppose a project over-draws an aquifer for a coastal industry, depleting and salting water the nation cannot spare and the rural herders need, when clean-energy-powered desalination and sustainable management could serve the need.

Working the five questions: **what is harmed? How does it threaten the water or fairness? What clean alternative exists? What heritage is at stake?** And which funders apply, and how to work safely? The driver is the state's development need, with the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim,

and the donor leverage as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the state needs development and will over-draw the water" to a real effort: document the depletion and its threat to the nation's water and the herders; show it is self-defeating for a water-scarce nation; offer the clean-energy-powered, sustainable alternative the nation itself aspires to; and invoke the funders' safeguards — all serving a real need, not merely refusing. That is a workable effort suited to Djibouti — one that presses the nation toward the sustainable, fair path it says it wants. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state: they turn what might seem an impossible target — a poor, indebted, strategically-bound nation pursuing development from necessity — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works with the nation's own constraints and aspirations rather than against its needs or its authority. The harm becomes a documentable threat to scarce water or heritage. The threat becomes the nation's own survival and fairness, turned into an argument. The alternative becomes the clean path the nation itself professes to want. The heritage becomes a unique place worth keeping. And the funders become the means to press an indebted state. That translation — from a poor, seemingly immovable nation pursuing survival into a set of specific actions that serve sustainability, equity, and the nation's own goals — is the first and most important thing a Djiboutian effort does, because it moves the fight from a doomed demand for sacrifice onto the ground of the nation's own aspirations and its funders' rules, where a poor nation and a sustainable future can both be served.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the water's sustainability, the equity, and the heritage, much of it gathered by the state and its funders. A water authority, a funder, a technical body, and the state itself all move on evidence — and in Djibouti, a clear record of the harm, its threat to the water and fairness, and the clean alternative is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Water, and the Aspiration

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its driver, and the harm** — the well field and the aquifer it depletes, the industry and the coast it fouls, the works and the salt lake they scar — and, decisively here, **how it threatens the water's sustainability and what the nation's own aspirations require**. Much of the water and energy data exists in the state's own strategies and its funders' studies. Establish exactly **what the project is, what it harms, and how it undermines the water and the nation's own goals**, because the harm-against-the-water-and-the-aspiration is the case's foundation.

Layer 2: The Depletion, the Inequity, and the Heritage

Document the harm. Establish the **water harm** — the aquifer's depletion, the salting, the scarce water lost — and the **inequity** — the rural herders denied while others are served — and the **heritage loss** — the salt lake, the forest, the coast and its life threatened — drawing on **the state's water and energy science, the funders' studies, the community's knowledge, and the international research**. This depletion-inequity-heritage evidence turns the harm into a threat to the nation's water, its fairness, and its unique heritage at once.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Alternative, the Funders, and the Path

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **science** prove depletion, inequity, or heritage loss? What **clean, fair alternative** — the nation's own aspiration — exists? Which **funders and safeguards** apply? And how will the effort **work through the system and the funders** with care? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that presses the nation toward sustainability with a fair alternative and the funders behind it. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented harm, a clean alternative, applicable funders, and a careful path are exactly what let a Djiboutian effort secure a sustainable, fair result. Build it well, and the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because so much of Djibouti's water, energy, and infrastructure is planned and financed with international partners, a great deal of the necessary evidence already exists in official and donor documents — the water strategies, the feasibility and environmental studies attached to funded projects, the sustainability analyses required by the lenders — and drawing on this existing record is often more effective than trying to generate evidence from scratch against a centralised state. The funders themselves commission studies of aquifer capacity, of environmental and social impact, of sustainability, as conditions of their finance, and those studies frequently contain precisely the findings an effort needs: that an aquifer is being over-drawn, that a project carries environmental risk, that a sustainable alternative exists. Building this layer well therefore means seeking out and drawing on that official and donor record, and using it to show, from the state's and the funders' own documents, what sustainability requires and where a project falls short. Evidence produced by the state and its funders, marshalled to hold them to their own findings and requirements, is the strongest possible foundation, and in a donor-financed state it is unusually available.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it exists in the state's own strategies and its funders' studies. Here is where the material tends to live in a Djiboutian effort, and how to get it — with the **water**, the **equity**, the **heritage**, and the **funders** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Water, Energy, and Aspiration Record

Start with the water and the nation's own goals, which are the foundation. **The water and energy strategies, the development vision, and the environmental law** establish the harm and the standard; the distinctive strengths here are the **water-sustainability data** and the **nation's own clean-energy and development aspirations**, much of it public or reachable through institutional and donor channels. Establish the **harm, its threat to the water, and what the nation's own goals require**, drawing on the state's and the funders' record. Establish exactly **what is harmed and against what aspiration**, because the harm-against-the-nation's-own-goals is what the state cannot easily dismiss.

The Depletion, Equity, and Science Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **depletion and salinity evidence** — the aquifer's decline, the rising salinity, the scarce water lost — and the **equity evidence** — the rural-urban gap, the herders denied, the unequal investment — drawing on **the water science, the funders' studies, the community's accounts, and the international research**. This depletion-and-equity evidence is what turns the harm into both a threat to the nation's water and an injustice to its rural people.

The Heritage and Clean-Energy Record

Document the heritage and the alternative. Gather the record of **the natural heritage** — the salt lakes, the relict forest, the coast, the mangroves, the reefs, the marine life, and the artisanal salt heritage — that a project threatens; and the **clean-energy and sustainable-water alternative** — the geothermal and renewable potential, the clean-powered desalination, the sustainable management — that the nation itself aspires to. A community that can show a unique heritage at stake and a clean, fair alternative in reach holds the levers that make opposition both protective and constructive.

The Funder, Regional, and International Record

Document the levers of finance and cooperation. Gather the record of the **international funders** of Djibouti's water, energy, and infrastructure and their safeguards and grievance mechanisms; the **regional water and development bodies** for the shared aquifers and the Horn's water; and the **international environmental and heritage partners**. A community joined to the funders' safeguards, the regional bodies, and the international partners holds levers that reach an indebted, donor-financed state where it is most responsive.

The People, the System, and the Care

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path. Who is affected — the **rural pastoralists, the coastal communities, the artisanal salt workers, and the water-short people** — and who can act: the **technical experts, what civil society exists, the funders, the regional and international partners**, since the space is constrained. And how does the effort **work through the system and the funders with care**, given the constraints? A Djiboutian effort is advanced largely through the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage, within the constraints — so map that coalition deliberately, and let care for those involved and a realistic sense of the crisis and the constraints govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the Djiboutian way, because open, adversarial organising is constrained in an authoritarian state, and the "opposition" that works joins the affected rural and coastal communities to the technical experts and the international funders, pressing through those channels. The task is to build a community — of pastoralists, coastal people, technical experts, and international partners — that presses for sustainable water, clean and fair development, and a heritage kept whole, on the nation's own aspirations and the funders' rules.

Why the Community-and-Funder Coalition Is Decisive

In Djibouti, the coalition that can act joins the affected communities to the technical experts and the funders, because a small, donor-financed, authoritarian state responds to sustainability, expertise, and its lenders more than to open dissent. That coalition supplies what an effort runs on: the rural and coastal people who bear the harm and hold the fair claim, the technical experts whose evidence the state and funders trust, and — distinctively — the international funders whose safeguards and finance shape the nation's development. When affected communities, experts, and funders press for a sustainable, fair path, they become a genuine force. **A coalition that joins the affected communities to the technical experts and the international funders here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the form advocacy can effectively and safely take in Djibouti — the real foundation of an effort, pressing a donor-financed state toward the sustainable, fair path it aspires to.** This is worth dwelling on, because the particular structure of Djibouti's situation makes the funder relationship unusually central, in a way that reshapes what effective advocacy

looks like. Djibouti's water, energy, and much of its infrastructure are financed not from its own thin revenues but from international development banks and donor partners, whose money comes attached to environmental and social safeguards, sustainability requirements, and grievance mechanisms. This means that an affected community, weak on its own before a centralised state, is not without recourse, because the funders who hold the purse strings have both the leverage to insist on sustainability and fairness and their own reputational reasons to do so. The task, therefore, is to weld the local and the financial: the community's testimony, rights, and knowledge on the ground, and the funders' safeguards, leverage, and finance from above. Neither alone is enough; the community lacks the leverage over the state, and the funders lack the local reality and the on-the-ground witness. Joined, they can press a donor-financed state toward sustainability and equity through the one channel it cannot easily ignore, which is the channel of the money it depends on.

Finding the Coalition

Begin with those the harm touches and those who can act — the **rural pastoralists, the coastal communities, the artisanal salt workers, the technical experts, and the international funders and partners** — and treat the constraints on open dissent honestly, protecting those involved. Widen to all who share the stake in Djibouti's water and heritage. Name the shared stake — **our water, our herds, our salt lakes and coasts, and our children's future** — because the environment is the nation's survival and its heritage. Frame the coalition around sustainability, fairness, and clean development, not around confrontation. There is real power in framing the cause this way, because it aligns the effort with the nation's own stated aspirations and its funders' own requirements, rather than against the state's authority or its genuine needs. A community that says "stop this project" pits itself against a poor nation's development and a strategic state's priorities, and casts itself as an obstacle. A community that says "let this development be sustainable, clean, and fair, as the nation itself says it wants and as the funders require" casts itself as the champion of the nation's own goals, and reframes the question from obstruction to the honest fulfilment of aspirations already professed. This framing is not only safer in a constrained space; it is also truer and more achievable, because Djibouti genuinely does aspire to clean energy and sustainable water, and its funders genuinely do require sustainability and safeguards, so the effort asks only that these professed commitments be honoured in practice. An effort that names this stake precisely — sustainable, clean, fair development, as the nation and its funders themselves espouse — stands on ground that is both strong and difficult to refuse.

Coalition-Building, Through the Community, Technical, and Funder Channels

A coalition allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Djibouti it runs through the affected communities, the experts, and the funders. Reach to the **rural and coastal communities**; the **technical and scientific experts**; the **international funders and their safeguards**; the **regional water and development bodies**; and the **international environmental partners**. Frame the coalition around the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage. Build breadth through these channels, favouring the technical and funder routes over open confrontation, and protecting those involved.

Sustaining the Effort

Djiboutian efforts are sustained through the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders. Keep the coalition **informed, connected, and careful**; mark real steps — a depletion slowed, a clean project advanced, a rural community served, a heritage protected, a safeguard enforced. And keep the effort grounded in sustainability, equity, and the nation's own aspirations, which carry weight within the system

and with the funders. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the affected communities to the experts and the funders, presses the nation's own goals, and works patiently through the channels that exist.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & RESOURCE-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE WATER SUSTAINABILITY, THE CLEAN-ENERGY PATH, AND THE DONOR LEVERAGE

This is where a Djiboutian effort is realistically advanced — not through open confrontation, which is constrained, nor mere refusal, which ignores a real need, but through the **water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage**, grounded in the nation's own aspirations and its funders' rules. Here the sustainability, clean-energy, and funder levers come together, because in Djibouti a project that depletes the water or harms the heritage, against the nation's own goals, when a clean alternative exists and the funders can insist, can be pressed through those levers.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work around a poor, indebted state's genuine need**. The sustainability case is **strong but the water crisis is real**; the clean-energy path is **the nation's aspiration but costly and slow**; the donor leverage is **genuine but depends on the funders' will**; and open challenge is **constrained**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the harm documented, the depletion curbed, the clean alternative advanced, the rural claim pressed, the heritage protected, and the funders engaged** — real outcomes, if not the transformation of a poor state's constraints. Enter this front clear-eyed: the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage are Djibouti's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm to the scarce water is proven, a clean alternative is offered, and the funders are engaged** — but the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, and the space constrained.

The Water Sustainability and the Clean-Energy Path

The first front is the water and the nation's own aspiration. In one of the world's most water-scarce nations, a project that **depletes or salts the groundwater** is self-defeating, so the **water-sustainability argument** — grounded in the state's own data and the funders' studies — is a genuine lever, because the nation cannot spare the water it wastes. And the **clean-energy path** the nation itself aspires to — the geothermal and renewable potential, the clean-powered desalination, the sustainable management — is the constructive alternative, meeting the need without depleting the water. Use the sustainability case and the clean-energy path together, because the water constraint and the nation's own goal are the case's core, and a water-scarce state committed to clean energy is exposed when it depletes the water or clings to dirty, wasteful projects. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this sustainability-and-clean-energy front, honestly. Its power is real: a nation this water-scarce cannot, on its own logic, afford to squander or salt the little water it has, and a nation that has publicly committed itself to becoming a clean-energy leader is exposed when it clings to unsustainable projects, so the argument reaches the state where its own survival and its own professed goals are at stake. Its limits are equally real: the clean-energy and sustainable-water alternative, though the nation's aspiration, is costly, slow, and dependent on finance the nation does not itself command, so a state under immediate pressure may reach for the quicker, dirtier, or more depleting option even against its own long-term interest. Understanding both means using the sustainability-and-clean-energy front for what it does best — exposing the self-defeating character of depleting scarce water and the gap between the nation's clean-energy aspiration and an unsustainable project — while always pairing it with the donor leverage that can supply the finance to make the clean alternative actually available, because a nation shown both that a project betrays its water and its

goals and that the funds for a better path exist is far more movable than one merely told its desperate choice is wrong.

The Rural Claim and the Natural Heritage

The second front is equity and heritage. The **rural herders' fair claim** — to the water and investment they are denied while the capital is served — is a powerful equity argument that the nation's own commitments to its people support. And the **natural heritage** — the unique salt lakes, the relict forest, the coast and its mangroves, reefs, and marine life, and the artisanal salt heritage — is worth more kept whole, for its people, its science, and its tourism, than industrialised or degraded. Press the rural claim and the heritage case, because fairness to the herders and the protection of a unique heritage are both just and persuasive, and both align with the nation's own stated goals.

The Donor Leverage and the Regional Cooperation

The third front is the funders and the region. The **international funders** of Djibouti's water, energy, and infrastructure — the development banks and partners — carry **safeguards and leverage** over an indebted state, and can insist on sustainability, equity, and clean alternatives, and offer the finance for them. And the **regional water and development bodies** — for the shared aquifers and the Horn's water — call for cooperation. Pursued together — the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage — these fronts are how a Djiboutian effort secures sustainable, fair development and a heritage kept whole, through the nation's own aspirations and its funders' rules, with care for those involved. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Djibouti's particular situation. The water sustainability supplies the argument a water-scarce nation cannot ignore without endangering its own survival. The clean-energy path supplies the constructive alternative that answers the development need and matches the nation's own goal. The rural claim supplies the equity dimension that fairness and the nation's commitments support. The natural heritage supplies the case for the unique places worth keeping whole. And the donor leverage supplies the practical means to press an indebted state through the finance it depends on. Each covers the others' limits: the sustainability where the water constraint must bite, the clean energy where an alternative is needed, the rural claim where equity is the point, the heritage where a unique place is at stake, and the donor leverage where the state must be moved through its funders. An effort that grasps this division of labour, and pursues each front together, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state uniquely provides.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of water, equity, and heritage becomes different arguments for the state, the funders, the technical bodies, and the world. Translate deliberately, and always offering a fair, sustainable path.

For the State and Its Agencies

The state responds to **the water crisis, its own aspirations, and its development goals**. Frame the harm as self-defeating and against its own goals: here is a project that depletes the water you cannot spare and betrays the clean, sustainable future you say you want. Give them the sustainability case and the clean alternative, and press for the path they themselves aspire to. Make it concrete: *here is the harm to our water, here is your own goal, here is a better way*. This is the argument that reaches a water-scarce state committed to clean energy.

For the International Funders

The funders respond to **their safeguards, their mandates, and sustainable investment**. Frame the harm as a breach of the protections and the sustainability they require: here is a project you fund depleting scarce water or harming a heritage, against your own safeguards. Give them the harm and the clean alternative, and invoke their safeguards and their leverage. A funder committed to sustainability and do-no-harm, with leverage over an indebted state, is a powerful ally.

For the Technical and Scientific Bodies

The technical bodies respond to **the science and the sustainability of the resource**. Frame the harm as a failure of sustainable management: here is the depletion, the salting, the loss, proven by the data. Give them the science and the alternatives, and enlist their expertise and standing. A technical body with the science and a mandate for sustainable water and energy is an ally within the system.

For the World and the Region

The world and the region respond to **a unique heritage and a shared water at risk**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: here is the lowest, saltiest lake, the relict forest, the whale-shark coast, or the herders left dry, threatened when a sustainable path exists. Frame it as the protection of a unique heritage and the fair, sustainable use of a shared, scarce water. Keep it accurate; credibility matters in a constrained space. And respect the nation's real need.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, never merely refuse, and work within the space with care. Your credibility rests on the real harm, the real alternative, and the real fairness of your ask — a sustainable, fair path, not obstruction; and care for those involved matters in a constrained space. State the harm precisely, tie it to the water and the nation's own goals, offer the clean alternative, and press within the system and the funders. An effort that is precise, constructive, and offers a real alternative is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or merely refuses, and far safer than one that courts confrontation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, distinctively, the story is one of a tiny, water-scarce nation choosing between depleting its precious water and pursuing the clean, fair path it aspires to, told with care and largely through international and technical channels in an authoritarian state. The story — the herders left dry, the salt lake or coast threatened, the clean future within reach — resonates, if told fairly.

Why Media Matters

The state, the funders, the technical bodies, and the world behave differently when the harm and the sustainable alternative are visible. Media does three things here: it **connects the affected communities to the technical and funder world**, it **raises the stakes** for a state mindful of its aspirations and its standing, and it **reaches the funders and the world** who expect sustainable, fair development. But Djibouti is an authoritarian state with limited media freedom, so the media effort runs largely through **international development and environmental media, the funders' channels, and careful factual documentation**, rather than confrontational domestic press — and with care for those involved.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the water, the fairness, and the clean alternative. The strongest frame is concrete and constructive: *in one of the world's most water-scarce nations, where herders are left dry, a project depletes the water we cannot spare and threatens a unique heritage — when the clean, sustainable future the nation itself wants is within reach*. Put the water and the fairness first, and the clean alternative close behind, because the scarcity and the inequity reach everyone and the alternative makes the case constructive. Keep it scrupulously accurate; overstatement is easily dismissed. The Djiboutian story is powerful because the water crisis is real and the clean path is the nation's own goal. This is the heart of the matter, and it is worth stating plainly why it gives a Djiboutian effort its distinctive force. The power of the case lies not in opposition from outside but in the nation's own predicament and its own professed goals turned into an argument: it is the nation itself that faces a water crisis so severe it cannot afford to waste a drop, the nation itself that has declared its aspiration to become a clean-energy leader, and the nation itself, financed by funders who require sustainability, that then risks depleting its water or clinging to unsustainable projects against both its survival and its stated aims. An effort that simply opposed a poor nation's development would forfeit the truth and invite the state's defences. An effort that instead holds up the nation's own water crisis and its own clean-energy aspiration against an unsustainable project, and offers the clean alternative with the funders' backing, asks only that the nation act in its own genuine interest and honour its own goals, which is a far harder thing for it to refuse and a far safer thing to demand. That is why the appeal to the nation's own survival and its own aspirations, rather than opposition to its development, is the strategic core of the entire Djiboutian approach.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the constraints. **International development and environmental media** for the funders and the world; **the funders' own accountability channels** for the safeguards; **technical and scientific publication** for the institutions; and **careful documentation** for the record. Because the domestic space is constrained, the international and funder channels matter most — a water-scarce nation choosing between depleting its water and the clean future it aspires to is the story's distinctive power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, fair, and respectful of the nation's need — the aim is a sustainable, fair path, not to exaggerate or endanger those involved. Frame the story around the water, the fairness, and the clean alternative, and be mindful of the constraints on dissent and the sensitivities of an authoritarian state and its powerful foreign partners. Handle the government, the geopolitics of the bases and the strait, the regional relations, and the debt factually and evenhandedly. And sustain the story through the ongoing water and development choices. Above all, let the real crisis and the real, aspired-to alternative carry the story, because that is where a Djiboutian effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real alternative, keep it factual, offer a fair path, and work within the space with care. Here the water's sustainability, and the funders, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — water and environmental impacts of [project]

To [water authority / ministry / agency],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [project] and its effects on [the aquifer / the coast / the salt lake / our community]. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **water-impact and environmental assessments**, the **abstraction and monitoring data**, and the **sustainability analysis** for the affected resource. We wish to support sustainable water and development in keeping with the national vision.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8B: The Water-Sustainability Argument

Subject: [Project] and the sustainability of our scarce water

To the [water authority / ministry],

Data show that [project] would [deplete the aquifer / salt the water / waste scarce water] in a nation that cannot spare it, undermining our water security and the sustainable future the national vision sets. We respectfully urge that it be reconsidered in favour of [clean-powered desalination / sustainable management / the clean alternative] that serves the need without depleting the water. We attach the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8C: Letter to an International Funder

Subject: Safeguards and sustainability concern regarding [project]

Dear [funder / development bank / grievance mechanism],

We write regarding [project], which you fund or may fund, and which would [deplete scarce water / harm a unique heritage / bypass sustainability]. We support sustainable, fair development, and respectfully request that your safeguards be applied, a sustainable alternative supported, and the affected communities protected. We provide the documentation and welcome your review.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8D: Proposing the Clean-Energy Alternative

Subject: Meeting the need through clean energy and sustainable water

To [energy / water authority / funder],

The need [project] seeks to meet could be served sustainably through [geothermal-powered desalination / renewable energy / sustainable management], in keeping with the nation's own aspiration to clean energy, sparing the scarce water it would deplete. We respectfully propose this path, which serves our development without the loss, and we offer to help. We attach the analysis.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8E: The Rural-Equity Claim

Subject: The rural communities' fair claim to water and investment

To [authority / funder],

Our rural and pastoralist communities, who bear the heaviest burden of water scarcity, are denied the water and investment the capital receives. We respectfully urge that [project / the water investment] be directed to serve them fairly, in keeping with the nation's commitment to its people, so that development reaches those who need it most. We attach our account.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8F: The Natural-Heritage Case

Subject: Protecting our unique heritage at [location]

To [authority / heritage / environmental body],

[Project] threatens [Lake Assal / the forest / the coast / the mangroves and reefs], a unique heritage of great natural, scientific, and cultural value, worth far more kept whole — for its people, its science, and its tourism — than industrialised or degraded. We respectfully urge its protection, and sustainable alternatives to the harm. We attach the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: A water-scarce nation's choice — deplete or go clean

Dear [journalist / editor],

In one of the world's most water-scarce nations, where herders are left dry, a project would deplete the water we cannot spare and threaten a unique heritage — when the clean, sustainable future the nation itself aspires to is within reach. There is a fair, resonant story here, and we can provide the science, the community's voices, and an account that honours both the crisis and the nation's own goals.

Sincerely,

[Name, group, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our water, our heritage, our future — let us secure them together

Dear neighbours,

Our scarce water is being depleted, our herders left dry, our salt lakes and coasts threatened — when a clean, fair future is within reach. Together — pastoralists, coastal people, experts, and partners — by documenting the harm, showing its threat to our water, offering the clean path the nation itself wants, pressing our rural claim, and invoking the funders, we can secure sustainable, fair development and a heritage kept whole, through the channels that exist and with care. Please join us: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a harm is acute — a well field over-drawing an aquifer, a coastal industry begun, salt works at the lake, a project fast-tracked — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the water-sustainability case, the donor leverage, and the technical experts.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — through sustainability and the funders: **what is harmed, and how it threatens the scarce water or the fairness owed**. Identify the immediate pressure point — **a well field, a coastal industry, salt works, a fast-tracked project** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **technical experts, the water authority, and any international funder** at once, because in Djibouti the sustainability case and the funders' safeguards are the fastest routes to real, and safer, leverage — and begin at once to sketch the **clean, fair alternative**, because refusal without it ignores the real need.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The water-sustainability argument** can be made at once, reaching a water-scarce state where it is most exposed. **The donor leverage** can be invoked quickly through the funders' safeguards. **The technical experts** can be engaged fast. **The rural-equity claim** can be raised immediately. These outpace the slower work of building clean-energy infrastructure and regional cooperation — which must follow — because the sustainability case and the funders can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if scarce water is being depleted, press the sustainability case fast, because that a water-scarce state can least afford to ignore.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the experts and funders fast. Reach immediately to the **technical experts, the water authority, the international funders, and the affected communities**. A coalition making the sustainability case, invoking the funders' safeguards, and offering a clean alternative is the most a rapid Djiboutian effort can do. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the sustainability case, and the clean alternative before the crisis breaks, and work through the channels that exist with care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by a genuine water and development crisis with few options, by a poor and heavily indebted state, by a constrained political space, and by a geopolitics of ports, bases, and powerful foreign partners that shapes much beyond ordinary reach. Name it plainly, because pretending the crisis is not real, or that the nation has good options it ignores, or that opposition is free, or that geopolitics does not dominate, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The crisis is real** — the nation genuinely lacks water and needs development. **The nation is poor and indebted** — its autonomy is limited by debt and dependence. **The space is constrained** — open dissent and independent civil society are limited. **And geopolitics**

dominates — the ports, the bases, and the foreign partners shape much of the nation's fate. This is a tilt of scarcity, poverty, constraint, and geopolitics, and an effort here works it through the water's sustainability, the clean-energy path, the rural claim, the heritage, and the donor leverage, within the constraints, not through mere refusal or open confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers that serve the real need and engage the funders. Lean on the **water-sustainability case**, which a water-scarce state cannot ignore; the **clean-energy path**, the nation's own aspiration; the **rural claim**, which fairness supports; the **heritage case**; and above all the **donor leverage**, which reaches an indebted state through its funders. Meet the development need not with refusal but with the clean, fair, funded alternative. And build the technical record and the funder relationships over time, because credibility and finance accumulate into influence. A field tilted by scarcity, poverty, and geopolitics is worked through sustainability and the funders, not by denying a poor nation its needs or confronting a strategic state head-on.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little visible change — the aquifer may still be drawn down, the project may proceed, the herders may stay dry — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the crisis is real and the constraints heavy. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented, the sustainability case was made, the clean alternative was offered, the rural claim was pressed, and the funders were engaged** — and every depletion slowed, every clean project advanced, every rural community served, every heritage protected, every safeguard enforced makes a real difference. Press for the sustainable, fair path; even if a project proceeds, the case you built and the alternative you offered will shape the next decision, because a nation running out of water cannot forever ignore the sustainability of its own survival.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Djibouti, alongside the genuine crisis, there can be a concern of opacity in the infrastructure, port, and resource deals that dominate the economy: contracts and debts struck without transparency, benefits captured by the few, and public resources not serving the public good. This must be approached with care in an authoritarian state, and the safer, more effective route runs through the international funders, the transparency standards, and the sustainability case.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

In many small, strategic, donor-financed states there is a line between the ordinary tilt of scarcity and geopolitics and the capture of resources by the few. The marks are specific: **infrastructure, port, or resource deals struck without transparency, debts whose terms and beneficiaries are unclear, benefits captured by elites while the public bears the cost, and public resources not serving the public good**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the genuine, honest constraints of a poor, strategic state from provable, documented opacity or capture**, and rely on the funders' transparency requirements, the sustainability case, and the international standards, because in a constrained space these are safer and more credible than accusation. And note that opaque, elite-capturing deals waste the very resources and finance a water-scarce nation most needs.

Responding to Capture — Through the Funders and the System, Carefully

Where opacity or capture is real, the response runs through the funders and the transparency standards. Use the **international funders and their transparency and safeguard requirements** to press for disclosure and accountability in the deals they finance. Use the **sustainability and equity case** to show that opaque, wasteful deals betray the nation's water and its people. Use the **international transparency standards** to insist on openness in infrastructure and resource governance. And use the **regional and international partners** to support transparent, sustainable development. Document carefully and protect those involved, because in a constrained space the record must be rigorous and the people shielded. Route the effort through the funders, the transparency standards, and the sustainability case — not through open confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters throughout. Djibouti is an authoritarian state with real limits on dissent and criticism of the government, and with powerful foreign partners, so this work must be done with care, largely through international, funder, and technical channels. Favour the **funders' channels, the technical and regional bodies, and careful documentation** over open confrontation; protect individuals, especially the rural, coastal, and marginalised communities and any local advocates whose position could be jeopardised; frame the work around the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules, not around challenging authority; and handle the government, the geopolitics of the bases and the strait, the foreign partners, and the debt factually and evenhandedly. Care here is not timidity; it is the recognition that the effective and safe path in Djibouti runs through sustainability, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage, and that pressing too openly can cost vulnerable people dearly while achieving less than patient work through the funders and the system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Djiboutian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the water-equity-heritage file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-and-funder coalition, organises the affected people, the experts, and the funders. **Legal, regulatory, and resource-governance** work presses the sustainability, the clean-energy path, and the donor leverage. **Media**, largely international, carries the sustainable-and-fair-development cause. The water-and-alternative feeds all five at once — a documented harm is a sustainability case, a clean-energy argument, a rural claim, and a funder appeal together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, joining community, experts, and funders, they compound into sustainable, fair development within the constraints.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm and the water-sustainability case; identify the clean alternative, the rural claim, the heritage, and the funders; build the community-and-funder coalition and begin documentation. **Middle (months 2–18):** press the sustainability case and the water authority; engage the funders and their safeguards; advance the clean-energy and sustainable-water alternative; press the rural claim and the heritage; and build the record. **Later (months and years):** secure sustainable water, clean

development, rural equity, and heritage protection, and defend against each new threat. A Djiboutian effort works through sustainability and the funders, and its fruits — documentation, clean projects, equity, protection — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let care govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm; show its threat to the water and fairness the nation needs; offer the clean-energy path the nation itself aspires to; press the rural claim and the heritage; invoke the donor leverage; and serve a real need.** The coalition that presses all five, joining community, experts, and funders, and serving the nation's own goals, is the one that can genuinely secure sustainable, fair development — the kind of result a poor, water-scarce, donor-financed state allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project in Djibouti is genuinely difficult, and bound up with a real water and development crisis that leaves the nation few good options, with poverty and heavy debt, with a constrained political space, and with a geopolitics of ports and bases that shapes much beyond ordinary reach, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, the space constrained, and geopolitics dominant. And yet the effort is far from futile, because water is Djibouti's binding constraint and a project that depletes it is self-defeating, because the nation itself aspires to the clean energy that could power a sustainable future, because the rural herders have a fair claim, because the salt lakes and coasts are a unique heritage worth keeping whole, and because the funders who finance Djibouti carry real leverage — and those levers of sustainability, clean energy, equity, heritage, and finance are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Water is the binding constraint — so a sustainability case reaches a water-scarce state where it is most exposed. The nation aspires to clean energy — its own goal is a lever for a sustainable path. The funders carry leverage over an indebted state. But the crisis is real, the nation poor and indebted, and alternatives, not mere refusal, are essential.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers of sustainability, clean energy, equity, heritage, and finance, and the honest weight of a genuine crisis and a constrained, geopolitically-shaped state.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm. Show its threat to the water and fairness the nation needs. Offer the clean-energy path the nation itself aspires to. Press the rural claim and the heritage. Invoke the donor leverage. And serve a real need — because in a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state, an effort that presses for sustainable, equitable, clean development, through the nation's own aspirations and its funders' rules, with a real alternative in hand and care for those who act, is the one that is both effective and just.

Djibouti is a tiny nation at a crossroads of the world, a place of ports and bases and camel caravans, of a salt lake that is the lowest and among the saltiest on earth, of a coast where whale sharks gather, and of herders who watch the wells run dry; and its gravest question is not a single project but whether, in one of the most water-scarce lands on earth, its people will have water to live and a heritage to keep. This guide has hidden none of that, nor pretended that a nation running out of water has easy choices, or that a poor, indebted, strategically-bound state has full autonomy, or that its political space is open, and there is no landmark victory to promise you. But the very thing that makes Djibouti's predicament so grave is also the lever: because water is the nation's binding constraint, a project that depletes it undermines the very survival the nation depends on, and can be pressed — on the nation's own terms, toward the clean and sustainable future it says it wants, with fairness to its herders, protection for its heritage, and the funders who finance it

insisting on all three. There is no easy victory, and no escaping the reality of the crisis and the constraints; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on care for those who act. But the water and heritage and people of Djibouti are worth defending, the levers that run through sustainability, the nation's own aspirations, and its funders' leverage are real, and the patient, careful work of documenting the harm, making the sustainability case, and pressing the clean, fair path is one a community can genuinely do — through the channels that exist — and secure water that lasts and a heritage kept whole. So can you.